

Republicans retain razor-thin lead in Senate race

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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The race for the Senate remains extremely close, with Republicans holding the slimmest edge at 55% odds in a contest that will come down to the wire.

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Strong Democratic candidates running against lackluster GOP campaigns make Ohio and Texas serious Republican vulnerabilities, while Alaska presents another real Democratic pickup opportunity, albeit one that will be hard to track given sparse polling and the complexities of ranked-choice voting; Republicans remain the favorites only because they need to win fewer toss-up races than do Democrats.

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The three key signposts to watch in the coming weeks are the generic congressional ballot, President Donald Trump's approval rating, and Democratic leads in individual races, any of which could trigger a reassessment of the overall outlook if they shift meaningfully.

The Senate race is extremely close, but Democrats face a high bar to become the favorites. Democrats have extended their run of good polling through August: On current numbers, their candidates have small leads in all competitive races except Iowa. Meanwhile, Republicans are still being dragged down by Trump's unpopularity and by the continued salience of the affordability issue. The task for Democrats is still daunting: hold all their own seats and flip four more, of which only one—North Carolina—is better than a toss-up.

We are maintaining our 55% odds that Republicans keep control of the chamber (see: The Senate race is now nearly a coin flip , 5 August 2026). This is down to three factors: Democrats' arithmetic problem, as they need to win more toss-up races than Republicans (see table below); our view that polls are likely to tighten following a Republican advertising blitz in the coming weeks, as they did in 2022; and a fundamentals-centric analysis that balances Democrats' small polling leads in states like Ohio and Texas against those states' strong Republican leans over the last decade. That said, our 55% probability reflects our low conviction, and a split 50-50 Senate looks more likely than ever.

Republicans remain the narrowest of favorites as Democrats have yet to reach key signposts. In our most recent update on the race, we laid out three signposts for flipping our call toward the Democrats:

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A Democratic generic congressional ballot lead of 8.5 points or more;

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A fall in Trump's approval rating below 36%;

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Continued Democratic polling leads in individual races into mid-September.

None of those signposts have yet been hit. Democrats' generic-ballot lead among registered voters remains between six and seven points and is under eight points even with a likely-voter filter applied; Trump's approval rating is languishing just above 38%, but hasn't fallen below that; and the durability of Democrats' polling leads is still in question. These remain our key signposts, and we will reevaluate the race later in September with these in mind.

Democrats' 45% odds to win the chamber are buoyed by recent strength in Michigan. Progressive Abdul El-Sayed has built a polling lead since the primary in early August, an undoubtedly positive sign for Democrats who had grown nervous about their chances with El-Sayed leading the ticket (see Abbreviated congressional schedule is new hurdle for Graham sanctions bill , 2 September 2026). Michigan is nearly a must-win state for Democrats; protecting their flank there has an outsize impact.

Both Texas and Ohio are serious vulnerabilities for Republicans, but for different reasons. In Texas, Democratic State Representative James Talarico's lead is the product of a favorable national environment, but also of Republican Attorney General Ken Paxton's major disadvantages as a candidate—namely, his personal controversies and his extremely lackluster fundraising efforts. Paxton is currently polling well below his fellow Republican, Governor Greg Abbott, suggesting candidate quality is the main issue. If Paxton does not see an influx of outside spending soon—in particular from Trump's national political action committee, which has just made its first commitment in the state—Republicans could well be at a disadvantage in Texas despite the state's GOP lean.

Ohio is probably a bigger vulnerability for Republicans. The Democrat, Sherrod Brown, is a populist former three-term senator who knows how to appeal to Trump voters and fell just short of reelection in a 2024 national environment that leaned Republican. The Republican incumbent, Jon Husted, was appointed to the seat to replace Vice President JD Vance, and national Republicans have serious concerns about his campaigning abilities. Moreover, Brown's campaign has portrayed Husted as a leading supporter of data centers, which have become deeply unpopular in the state. These factors have made this race look potentially as weak for Republicans as the Maine contest.

Alaska will be the most unpredictable race. Democrat Mary Peltola received just under 50% of the vote in the August all-party primary, which is a good sign for her, but not dispositive; she won 51% of the vote in the 2024 House primary, but went on to lose the general election. What could help Peltola, beyond her qualities as a candidate, are the vagaries of Alaska's ranked-choice system. She is the only Democrat in the four-candidate general election, facing three Republicans; if not all Republican voters complete their ballots, Peltola would likely benefit, which could be enough to matter in a razor-thin race.

Noah Daponte-Smith

Senior Analyst, United States

daponte-smith@eurasiagroup.net

Clayton Allen

Practice Head, United States

+1 202.903.0027

allen@eurasiagroup.net

EG United States

unitedstates@eurasiagroup.net

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